

Butternut Squash Information Pack

Introduction

Our Butternut supplier has their main farm and packhouse in West Sussex, just around the corner from Chef's Farms HQ. The UK Butternut season is October-February. Outside that window, we move into Senegal, then Greece and Spain to ensure year-round supply. Each of these satellite farms grows to the same specification and sustainability standards

Farm information

Our UK Butternut farm and import hub for out of season are both on the same site in West Sussex. Here, butternut is grown in rotation with sweetcorn, bean and brassicas to maintain the health and structure of the fertile soil in this region. The import partners are all in the same farming family, ensuring continuity and traceability for this crop throughout the season.

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Growing a diverse range of crops, and rotating year on year, is a key tenet of sustainable agricultural practice. Each different plant type extracts a slightly different selection of nutrients from the soil, so if you continuously plant the same crop in the same field you will find yourself deficient in those nutrients, so you must switch it up with a crop rotation. Similarly, pests tend to be plant specific, so breaking the cycle with a totally different kind of plant will keep the pests 'on their toes' as it were. Finally, squash grow on a sprawling ground level vine with huge leaves which dominate the surface and reduce the amount of light available to weeds, whilst ensuring the soil is covered and protected from erosion.

Due to their low water content squash can be stored for months on end without going bad and so also represents a great commercial opportunity for farmers to diversify their income into the winter months when many other crops are out of season

Nutritionally squash is rich in beta-carotene (a precursor to vitamin A), which supports eye and immune health, and it provides a good amount of vitamin C, potassium, and fiber. Squash also contains antioxidants that help reduce inflammation, and its complex carbohydrates offer slow, steady energy.